

of errors. Another important feature, almost a must-have, is an exit strategy, like the Cancel button. It promotes a feeling of safety and conditions the user to feel confident when using your product or service. Does the user always have a way out?

While you're giving the user control over their visible experience, as the UX designer you should have control over their subconscious experience. Sounds like a tall order? Well, it's certainly not, and this is what separates the best from the rest. Does your design ensnare the user's attention? Does it make him/her want to come back for more? It's as simple as applying a basic technique from human psychology, you read a few lines ago: "Conditioning". Want someone to do the same thing again? Reward them after they do it. Want them not to do it? Punish them. (Hey, don't grab that whip from your closet. That's not what we meant.) The key thing to remember here is to keep the rewards and punishments subliminal. A pop-up saying "Good Job!" invokes no feelings, but watching your crops grow does, somehow. After mastering the art of inducing feelings of reward or punishment, promoting addiction is only a matter of creating an appropriate feedback loop. Think Facebook: Feel like posting -> Post -> Get likes -> Feel good -> Post again. The social media giant capitalised on one of our basic needs – societal recognition – and now you can do it too! If you don't want to take advantage of this particular need, there are about thirteen other commonly accepted ones! It's up to you to use them.

Are you in control?

A few more lamp posts – Dieter Rams' 10 principles

1. Good Design Is Innovative – It contains just enough novelty.
2. Good Design Makes a Product Useful – It solves currently existing problems.
3. Good Design Is Aesthetic – It's pleasing to the eye.
4. Good Design Makes a Product Understandable – And thus more widely used.
5. Good Design Is Unobtrusive – It fits without displacing anything.
6. Good Design Is Honest – It doesn't appear to be more than it is.
7. Good Design Is Long-Lasting – It doesn't follow fashion.
8. Good Design Is Thorough Down to the Last Detail – Everything has a purpose.
9. Good Design Is Environmentally Friendly – As everything should be.
10. Good Design Is as Little Design as Possible – Painstakingly made simple.